

Glossary

ACHENE A dry, one-seeded fruit. All plants in the buttercup family have achenes.

ALGA A simple nonflowering plant that usually lives in water. Algae include seaweeds and many microscopic species.

ANGIOSPERM A flowering plant. Unlike gymnosperms, angiosperms grow their seeds inside a protective case called an ovary, which develops to form a fruit.

ANNUAL A plant that completes its life cycle within the growing season of one year.

Green alga, or seaweed

ANTHER The tip of a flower's stamen containing pollen.

AXIL The angle between the upper part of a stem and a leaf or branch. Buds develop in the axil.

AXIS The main stem or root in a plant.

BIENNIAL A plant that has two growing seasons. The seed is sown in the first year and flowers and fruits in its second year. The plant then dies.

BOTANY The scientific study of plants.

BRACT A small, leaflike flap that grows just beneath a flower.

BUD The first visible sign of a new limb of a plant, or the protective case that encloses a flower that is still growing inside.

BULB An underground stem that stores food inside layers of fleshy scales. Most plants use bulbs to survive drought or cold.

BULBIL A small bud that grows into an independent plant.

BURR The prickly seed case of some plants.

CALYX The ring of sepals that protects a flower bud. The calyx often falls off when the flower blooms.

CARPEL The female organ of a flower. It consists of the stigma, the style, and the ovary.

Daffodil bulbs

CELL The smallest possible unit of living matter, visible only under a microscope. A cell consists of a nucleus surrounded a fluid called cytoplasm and bounded by a cell wall.

CHLOROPHYLL The green pigment present in all plants and algae and involved in the process of photosynthesis.

CHLOROPLAST A microscopic green structure that contains chlorophyll and which is found inside a plant cell. Chloroplasts capture energy from sunlight.

CLIMBER A plant that grows upward and outward, attaching itself to structures such as walls and fences.

COROLLA The ring of petals in a flower.

COTYLEDON A specialized leaf that is prepicked inside a seed. Cotyledons often look very different from ordinary leaves.

DECIDUOUS A plant that loses its leaves every fall.

DICOT A plant whose seeds have two cotyledons (seed leaves). The leaves of a dicot, or dicotyledon, are often broad, and they have veins arranged in a network.

EMBRYO A young plant in its earliest stages of development.

ENDOSPERM A supply of food that is stored inside a seed. The endosperm fuels the seedling's early growth.

EVERGREEN A plant that retains its leaves all year round, such as pines and firs.

FILAMENT The stalk of a stamen that supports the anther.

FLORET A small flower that forms part of a composite flower, or flower head.

GERMINATION When a seed begins to sprout and grow.

GYMNOSPERM A plant whose seeds do not develop inside an ovary. Most gymnosperms are coniferous trees.

HARDY Being able to withstand extremes of temperature, such as cold and frost.

MONOCOT A plant whose seeds have a single cotyledon (seed leaf). The leaves of a monocot, or monocotyledon, usually have parallel veins.

MULTICELLULAR Made up of more than one cell.



Microscopic view of typical plant cells

NECTAR A naturally occurring sweet liquid found in the glands of many flowers.

OVARY A female reproductive organ that encloses fertilized seeds.

OVULE A collection of female cells that form a seed after they have been fertilized by pollen.

PAPPUS A ring or parachute of very fine hair that grows above a seed and helps it to be dispersed by the wind.

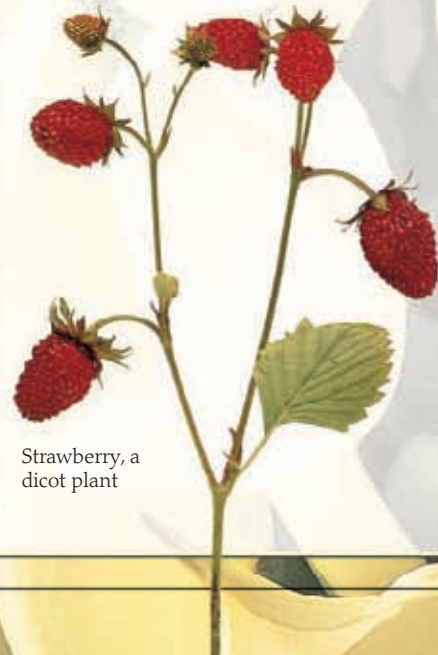
PARACHUTE Any structure that aids the spread of seeds by the wind, such as a pappus.

PARASITE An organism that lives in or on another organism, or host, from which it takes food and energy without giving anything back in return.

PERENNIAL A plant that lasts or flowers for more than two years.

PERIANTH The part of a flower made up of the calyx and the corolla together.

PETAL A leafy flap in a flower, often brightly colored to attract animal pollinators.



Strawberry, a dicot plant